

TO RETAIN ITS SEATS, THE BJP MUST ADDRESS THE DISAFFECTION AMONG THE COMMUNITIES IT WOOED IN 2019, LIKE THE OBC KURMIS OF THE WEST

racket in which TMC heavyweight Anubrata Mondal was arrested; the alleged coal smuggling scam in which Abhishek himself has been questioned by the Central Bureau of Investigation and the ED; and the PDS ration scam in which state minister Jyoti Priya Mallick was arrested in October 2023. Even as early as 2022, Abhishek had set in motion a concerted damage control exercise, most notably with a cabinet reshuffle where eight new ministers with clean records were inducted. Abhishek, also the Diamond Harbour MP, travelled across the state for 60 days in April-June 2023 in the Trinamooley Nabo Jowar (New Tide in TMC) campaign, assuring disillusioned voters that the party was undergoing a massive course connection.

Abhishek, quite the new guard, had also masterminded the TMC's landslide win in 2021—he brought in poll strategist Prashant Kishor and boldly dropped many sitting MLAs—snaffling 213 seats at a 48 per cent vote share, and limiting the BJP to 77 seats despite its 38 per cent share in votes. Perfected during the Nabo Jowar rally, Abhishek's image—in a full-sleeve white shirt, black trousers, a scarf around his neck, addressing supporters from atop a car—has embedded itself in the public consciousness. It has become his signature style this poll season.

Like in 2021, the TMC's candidate list for the Lok Sabha polls has Abhishek's imprint. According to party leaders, he had a hand in fielding BJP turncoats Biswajit Das, Krishna Kalyani and Mukut Mani Adhikari from Bongaon, Raiganj and Ranaghat respectively, and two former cricketers with tenuous connections with Bengal—Yusuf Pathan (Baharampur) and Kirti Azad (Durgapur-Burdwan).

The TMC is banking on the millions of beneficiaries of around 30 state welfare schemes. Besides, there's competition for welfare loyalties with the Union government—for instance, with parallel free ration schemes—and people are encouraged to be grateful to a munificent Didi. The marquee scheme is the Lakshmir Bhandar, which entails a direct transfer of a Rs 1,000 monthly honorarium to women.

'Anti-Bengali' Party

One major poll issue for the TMC is the cessation of central funds under the NREGA and the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Grameen (PMAY-G). New Delhi cites widespread corruption charges against the state administration. The TMC, hotly denying the charges, projects this as gross injustice done towards Bengal and paints Modi and the BJP as "anti-Bengali". Recently, the state cleared Rs 3,732 crore—a part of wages due under NREGA—from its own coffers and decided to start a state-sponsored programme guaranteeing 50 days' work to job card holders. A newly-coined TMC slogan goes: *Janaganer Garjan, Bangla Birodhider Bisarjan* (The roar of the people...will drown the anti-Bengalis). The CAA has also handed the TMC a conveniently-timed matador's red rag. Tying it with the controversial National Register of Citizens (NRC) and the Uniform Civil Code (UCC), Mamata has been exhorting people, especially her dependable Muslim vote bank comprising 27 per cent of the electorate, to resist them. The TMC's game is to ratchet up the CAA theme so as to eliminate chances of Muslim votes getting split among anti-BJP parties. The BJP disagrees. "TMC fooled Muslim brethren in 2021 by politicising the CAA. They have realised that it doesn't take away their citizenship," says Adhikari. Other BJP leaders, including Modi and Shah, have strenuously denied that registration under the CAA will lead to a loss of citizenship. The TMC manifesto has stated that if voted to power, it will repel the CAA, discontinue the NRC and not implement the UCC.

The BJP Game Plan

For the BJP, the CAA is not without a vote bank of its own. Its implementation is important for the Matuas—a Dalit community that migrated from East Pakistan during and after Partition, though its practical aspects seem a touch ambiguous. Still, the Matuas number over three million and determine the poll outcome in five seats in North 24 Parganas and Nadia, including the BJP-held Ranaghat (SC) and Bongaon (SC) seats. The BJP won their support in both 2019 and 2021.

The upper end of the BJP's stated ambition is to win 30 out of the 42 seats in Bengal, but it's not without signs of internal friction. Adhikari's hand is writ large on its list of candidates, with many TMC turncoats being fielded—among them Tapas Roy (Kolkata Uttar) and Arjun Singh (Barrackpore)—and former state president Dilip Ghosh shunted from his incumbent seat of Medinipur to Bardhaman-Durgapur. Former justice Abhijit Gangopadhyay (Tamluk) is a new entrant.